crime. The BJP may have weaponised the R.G. Kar incident to highlight the lack of women's safety under TMC rule, even successfully fielding the victim's mother, Ratna Debnath, from Panihati, but the end of the TMC regime will not automatically mean the return of law and order. Having once been part of the TMC himself, Suvendu perhaps knows its 'cut money' culture only too well and how to beat the party at its own game. Securing the state's borders to prevent infiltration from Bangladesh, a prominent theme of the BJP's poll campaign, is another tough to-do. The Bengal strongman has proved his mettle at winning elections, he must now demonstrate how he can bring the '*badlav*' (change) he has been elected for.

THE POLITICAL PREDICAMENTS

Nabanna's new sheriff has hit the ground running. In a significant departure from the one-woman show that was Mamata Banerjee, where you could not tell the party organisation from the state administration, the new CM and his party have made it clear that they will coordinate, but function independently of each other. BJP state president Samik Bhattacharya remarked that the administration would not be "BJP's government, because it is the West Bengal government". But the Centre's shadow, as Big Brother, could well loom large over the state's functioning. Suvendu's first order of business was the instating of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Ayushman Bharat scheme, both of which the Mamata government had objected to.

Suvendu will have to contend with several political heavyweights within the state BJP, including Dilip Ghosh, who has not always seen eye to eye with the new chief minister

But Suvendu's challenges could also well lie within. The state BJP has several influential heavyweights, among them Dilip Ghosh, who has never shared a particularly warm rapport with Suvendu. A former state BJP president and MP, Ghosh had fallen out of favour with sections of the party leadership in recent years but has now made a political comeback with the backing of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh. As part of the new Bengal cabinet, he has been given charge of the crucial panchayat and rural development department along with animal husbandry and agricultural marketing. Four others took the oath of office alongside the CM, among them two of his closest loyalists from his days as Leader of the Opposition, Agnimitra Paul and Ashok Kirtania, as well as former Union minister of state for home affairs and youth affairs and sports, Nisith Pramanik, and first-time MLA Khudiram Tudu. However, Suvendu will have to consider loyalty, factional interests and organisational expectations while forming the larger cabinet.



PTI

A JOB WELL DONE Suvendu Adhikari greets PM Narendra Modi after taking oath as CM, Kolkata, May 9

Meanwhile, his personal style of functioning is already becoming a subject of discussion within bureaucratic and political circles. A retired bureaucrat who worked with him when he was a minister in Mamata's cabinet describes his presence as "imposing" and occasionally even "intimidating". Yet, he also recalls how Suvendu would listen carefully and remain open to persuasion. "I can recollect multiple instances when I had differences with him," says the official. "But he would give an ear to our logic and reasoning. If you could make your case, Suvendu babu would retreat."

In his first two days as CM, Suvendu, sources in the administration say, appeared receptive and accessible. "It seems he is on a mission to prove he is not like his predecessor," one police officer says, on condition of anonymity. This became evident in Suvendu's very first cabinet meeting at Nabanna, where the CM signalled a sharp administrative and political reset with a series of decisions. These included